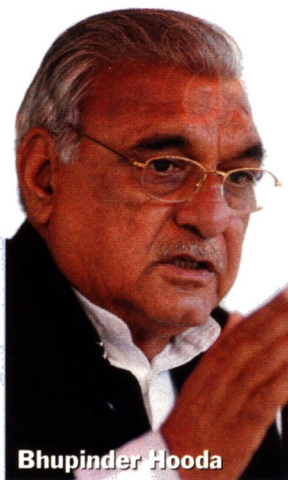


YASBANT NEGI

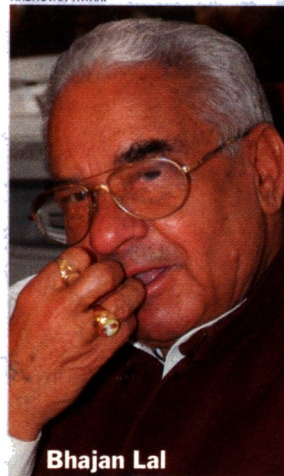


Bhupinder Hooda

JATLAND WARRIORS

The turf war dates back to 2005 when Hooda was made Haryana chief minister instead of Bhajan Lal. Earlier this year, Lal's son Kuldip Bishnoi accused Hooda of taking bribes to set up SEZs. When this boomeranged and the Congress suspended Bishnoi, the father-son duo decided to quit the Congress and launch a new party at a rally in Rohtak, Hooda's home town. An amused Hooda called it "a tea-party". Of course, he wasn't invited.

TIRBHUVAN TIWARI



Bhajan Lal

FUTURE TENSE

After the Gujarat defeat, Congress will find itself being pushed around by its allies and Sonia will have no option but to be more accommodating, especially of the Left Front. More so as the Congress is expected to take on BJP in at least five state polls this year. The on again-off again Third Front has gained ground and will tempt disgruntled Congress allies.

Others are exploring options too. If the Congress makes Narayan Rane chief minister of Maharashtra, NCP could walk over to the BJP-Shiv Sena alliance. Unhappy with the Congress, Ram Vilas Paswan could tie up with Nitish Kumar.

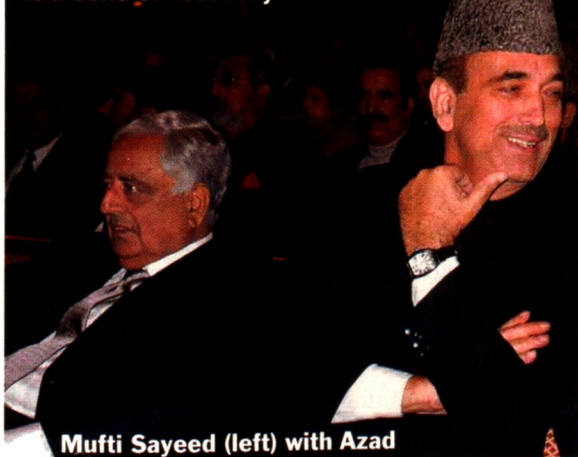
For BJP, the troubles lie within. Fresh from his Gujarat victory, Modi will play a key role in BJP's decision-making process. Expect Rajnath's rivals to prop him against the chief.

Compiled by
Priya Sahgal

YASIN DAR

VALLEY OF DISCORD

It's not so much a personality clash as it is a battle of ideologies. The Congress disagrees with Mufti Mohammed Sayeed's demand for demilitarisation and self-rule for Kashmir. At a personal level, Chief Minister Ghulam Nabi Azad has a much better rapport with the Abdullahs than the Sayeeds. But an alliance with the National Conference would eat into the Congress vote bank in Jammu. Like many arranged marriages, the Mufti-Azad alliance is a bond of necessity rather than choice.



Mufti Sayeed (left) with Azad

COMRADES IN COMBAT

The duo could well be the Vajpayee and Advani of the Left. While V.S. Achuthanandan enjoys mass support, state secretary Pinarayi Vijayan is the strategist who controls the organisation. Ever since Vijayan was overlooked for chief ministership in favour of his mentor-turned-rival, infighting has touched a new high. Punishment for this public washing of dirty linen came in the form of the CPI(M) leadership suspending both from the politburo for four months.

Pinarayi (left), Achuthanandan



SHANKAR



GIREESH GV

THE BUDDHA'S ORDEAL

SUBIR HALDER



The Trinamool leader ended 2006 with a 25-day fast protesting against land given to the Tatas in Singur. In 2007, Nandigram was her pet issue against the chief minister. Even when he expressed regret over the incident, she was not satisfied but called him an "incorrigible sinner".

Buddhadeb (left), Mamata



SIPRA DAS